American Son

By Christopher Demos-Brown

Suggested Roles:

ACTRESS: *Kendra Ellis-Connor: African American, recently separated from Scott and Officer Stokes: African-American; career police officer.*

ACTOR 2: *Officer Larkin: White, young, with career ambitions who lacks life experience. and Scott Connor: White, FBI agent, recently separated from Kendra.*

NOTE: This cutting asks the each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

In a police station waiting room. She is on her phone.

KENDRA: **(Pg 9-11)** *(on the phone)* Jamal – dammit where are you. I've sent you five texts now. You can't text me back? Call me.

LARKIN: *(enters)* OK . . . so I checked and the care does show up in the system. Coulda been ticketed. Coulda been towed.

KENDRA: Jamal – my son- was driving it. He's been gone since 8 o'clock last night. Going on nine hours. And when I called the police, they said something happened to the car – Hold on – I wrote it down. *(checking a scrap of paper in her purse)* "Identified in an incident."

LARKIN: I'm sure he's gonna turn up.

KENDRA: He has work – a very prestigious internship. This isn't like him. Can't you do a missing persons report . . . something?

LARKIN: Not for 48 hours, no. Look . . . he's sixteen?

KENDRA: Just turned 18.

LARKIN: **(Pg 16)** *(heavy sigh)* Lemme see what I can find out, OK? **(Pg 13-15)** But I'm gonna need some additional information. *(takes out a note pad and pencil)* First name again?

KENDRA: Jamal. J-A-M-A-L

LARKIN: Last name "Connor." DOB?

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KENDRA: 5/1/*1998*. (should 17 years before the year of the performance)

LARKIN: Has he ever been arrested before?

KENDRA: He's never so much as torn a tag off a new mattress, OK?

LARKIN: No AKA's . . . you know "also known as." Like street names.

KENDRA: *(sarcastically)* A "street name"? Like "Peanut" or "Black"?

LARKIN: Just in case he might have been printed for . . . (I don't know; whatever) I need to make sure we have all the correct information.

KENDRA: Fine. [He's] 6'2"; 185. Glasses. Cornrows. Light green eyes. **(Pg 16)** Are there that many 6'2" Black boys involved in "incidents" tonight? **(Pg 22)** Please. Go. Find Jamal. Find my son. *(Larkin exits; beat)* Unbelievable.

INTRODUCTION

A summer storm is raging outside a Miami police station and inside, as well, where an interracial couple, black mother/white father, await news of their missing son. As two policemen, one white, one black, pursue details of the missing youth, all four characters become engulfed in a battle of bias, judgment and racial prejudice. With the fate of a child at risk, tensions mount, and fear grows that the answers will never be as simple as black or white.

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KENDR: **(Pg 26-27)** *(Scott enters)* Jesus Christ, Scott.

SCOTT: It's OK. It's gonna be fine.

KENDRA: They haven't told me anything, Scott. They don't even know if Jamal's been arrested / or if he's in custody . . .

SCOTT: Dammit. I got him the car. **(Pg 30)** The Lexus is registered to me. **(Pg 27)** It's 4 am, I haven't even had a friggin' cup of coffee yet.

KENDRA: **(Pg 31)** *(full of reproach)* I've been here for almost an hour.

SCOTT: **(Pg 35-37)** *(beat)* Where was he last night? I assume he went out? With who? *(beat)* Kendra? Listen. You insisted J live with you. But you took on an obligation to be responsible. The kid is going to West Point in like a month. It's just not acceptable that he -- Kenny, the last few times he's stayed at my place, he's

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looked like a damn gangster.

KENDRA: Why? 'Cause he's not wearing Brooks Brothers?

SCOTT: Baggy pants, cornrows. That stupid, loping, surly walk he's suddenly developed.

KENDRA: You just don't get it. He's just trying to figure out who he is. His world is not ***your*** world, Scott.

SCOTT: His world is definitely my world. We spend almost a quarter of a million dollars putting that kid through the best private schools. He's had every possible advantage. I will not accept him regressing into . . .

KENDRA: Into what?

SCOTT: Obviously something happened. He was driving around with two Black kids.

KENDRA: **(Pg 38-40)** He's got a right to be in a car with his friends without getting dragged downtown at 3 am. Even if he's in a car with his ***Black*** friends. You think our bougie son has no right to associate with other Black kids?

SCOTT: I think our half-White, half-Black, who-gives-a-shit-what-race-he-is son – the one who got a 1470 on his SAT and aced AP Physics – know better'n to commit unforced errors in life by taking stupid risks. The way you present yourself I life has consequences.

KENDRA: Scott – not matter how many privileges he's got, the world still looks at him like it looks at me. . . not ***you***.

SCOTT: Boy, I'll tell ya . . . I can see exactly what's been happening. I'm outta the house a few months and you've been pumping his mind full of victimhood psychobabble.

KENDRA: I've done nothing of the sort. Instead of pointing the finger at me, maybe you oughta be looking in the mirror. You're the one who walked out on him.

SCOTT: *(beat)* I did not.

KENDRA: You did. I'm sorry, but that's exactly what you did. You up and walked out on him.

SCOTT: I didn't walk out on ***him***. I walked out on ***you***! *(long beat)* Look – J's on his way to being a commissioned office at one of the most elite institutions on earth. My job

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is done. He's a man now. **(Pg 42-43)** This is just some frivolous nonsense. He probably had his music cranked up too loud. Just . . . keep cool, half an hour – the 3 of us'll be at Denny's having a "teachable moment."

KENDRA: (Pg 44) Scott, listen to me . .

LARKIN: (Pg 45-46) *(enters with coffee)* Sorry to interrupt. Coffee. No cream, no sugar. I got some more information. *(reading from his note pad)* Your son was identified as a vehicle occupant in a traffic stop. There were two other Black males in the vehicle: DeShawn Rolle and Jarvis Bell, a 20-year-old with misdemeanor convictions. He had an open warrant. *(scans notes)* A bumper sticker on the back of your Lexus: "Shoot Cops with your phone whenever they make a bust." Shoot Cops in like huge letters. The rest in little-bitty font so's all anyone could see was a Lexus that said "Shoot Cops."

KENDRA: (Pg 47) It's about camera phones not guns, Jesus.

SCOTT: Did you know? Please tell me you didn't know about this.

KENDRA: There are three Black kids in his school. Out of 400 something and the other two are dating each other.

SCOTT: Right. No. I totally get it. Being one of the only Black kids at the most expensive prep school in the city entitles you to put a bumper sticker on your Lexus that says "shoot the stupid dumbass who got me this car"

KENDRA: He's depressed. He's confused. He's grappling with a lot right now.

SCOTT: Bullshit.

KENDRA: (Pg 48-49) *(to Larkin, confrontational)* You know what? I sat around here almost an hour, you couldn't tell me a damned thing. But as soon as my husband walks in – my White husband – all of the sudden you're helpful as can be. Why is that? *(Larkin exits)(to Scott)* Put yourself in Jamal's place. He's the only Black person most of those White kids at his school know. His White friends think he represent the entire race. *(beat)* That bumper sticker was . . .

SCOTT: Was what? No, really – I want to understand.

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KENDRA: Filming the cops is all these kids have. It's their last line of defense. God forbid I'm stopped – it's mine too. That's the world we live in. Whether you get it or not. You really thing that's what this is about? A bumper sticker?

SCOTT: **(Pg 50-52)** Look – if I'm a cop rolling down the street at 2 am and it's a close call on probable cause **. . .**

KENDRA: The bumper sticker would push you over the edge?

SCOTT: Especially if I get some uppity asshole lecturing me on his rights.

KENDRA: "Uppity?" Is that what you just said?

SCOTT: Dammit, don't make this about how I tripped on some coded word fossil. I can't have J lapsing into a life where he makes excuses for himself all the time. I won't.

KENDRA: And I won't have him walk around apologizing for who he is.

SCOTT: No one's asking him to do that.

KENDRA: Oh yes they are. "Keep your hands on the wheel, boy. Look straight ahead and don't make any sudden moves. Wouldn't wanna make the man with the bulletproof vest nervous when he walks up to your window with a Glock pointed at your head."

SCOTT: I'm as eager to sort this out as you are. He's my son too. I just don't think lecturing these people about Black Lives Matter is gonna help. Let's just try catching flies with honey, OK?

KENDRA: Maybe they need a little lecture. They sure finna get one when I sue they asses.

SCOTT: All I'm sayin' – let's not act like we're in some back-asswards Klan county in South Carolina. This is Miami, for God's sake.

KENDRA: *(with sarcasm)* Yassa, Massa Scott. Aunti Kendra don won hoit noboby feelins. Sorry, Massa Scott. **(Pg 54-55)** OK – know what? I'm not running cover for you anymore. He put the bumper sticker on the car to get back at you.

SCOTT: For what?

KENDRA: What do you think, Scott? For leaving him. Sorry – "leaving ***me***." That's what all

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this is about. The bumper sticker. The cornrows. It's a rebellion. Against you. For the first time in his life, he hates being half White. So get off my back about this 'cause you don't get to claim the high road here!

********* The Report*******

STOKES: **(Pg 73-74)** *(with no emotion, to audience as if giving a report to the media)* Jamal Connor was a rear seat passenger in a vehicle with a Jarvis Bell and a DeShawn Rolle. The car was tailed by a Metro cruiser near the Scott Projects in Liberty City where the driver was observed purchasing marijuana. Officer Rodney Banks pulled the car over. The camera shows the officer returns to his vehicle checking identification on his laptop. After 30 seconds, Mr. Bell exits the vehicle and attempts to approach the officer. The officer pulls his gun and gets Mr. Bell to the ground.

As the officer calls for backup, Rolle exits from the rear of the vehicle. Jamal Connor exits the vehicle. Jarvis Bell begins to stand up and take flight. The officer, now confronted with all 3 vehicle occupants

SCOTT: *(scared)* Oh, no . . .

STOKES: Fires three shots at the fleeing suspect. Either a stray shot or a ricochet . . . CSI is at the scene now . . . strikes Jamal Connor in the head killing him instantly.

SCOTT: I can't breathe. I . . . I. . . can't breathe . . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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